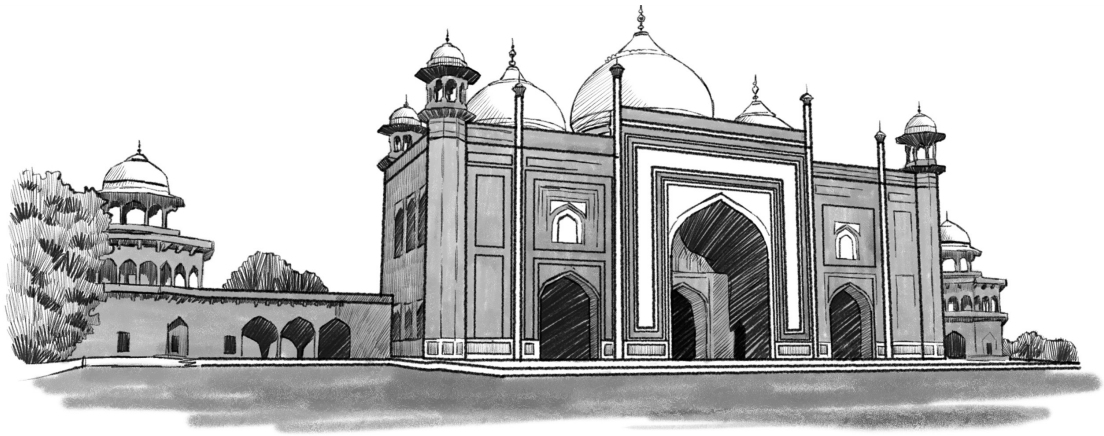


Shah Jahan wanted the complex to be so wonderful that many people would come to visit. So to the west of the mausoleum he planned a mosque made of red sandstone. The floor would be covered with the outlines of 569 prayer rugs in black marble. (Muslims use rugs to kneel on when they pray.)

Everything in the complex had to be symmetrical—that means the two sides mirror each other. So on the opposite side of the mausoleum would be a building that looked just like the red sandstone mosque. It was to serve as a place for important guests to stay. The guest house became known as the mosque's *jahab*, or "echo." Both of the red sandstone buildings would have domes exactly half as high as the tomb's dome.

The tomb was going to be beautiful beyond compare. But the view from it was also very important. The Taj would look down onto a walled garden. This garden was to reflect the Muslim idea of Paradise. Shah Jahan recalled his wife's dying wish, and declared, "May the Abode [home] of Mumtaz be Paradise." He even had a message inscribed on the red sandstone gate leading into the Taj Mahal.

But O thou soul at peace,
Return thou unto thy Lord, well-pleased,
and well-pleasing unto Him,
Enter thou among My servants
And enter thou My Paradise.